

“The Future of EXPO” *Project Future Life Worlds*

Creative Student Project



We have prepared videos for 4 scenarios and 2 videos for persons, all these videos are published on the developed website:

- <https://gftm-team.my.canva.site/dagp9nrfnwo/#introduction>
- Final presentation

How can an EXPO 2035 prepare humanity for the world in 2045?

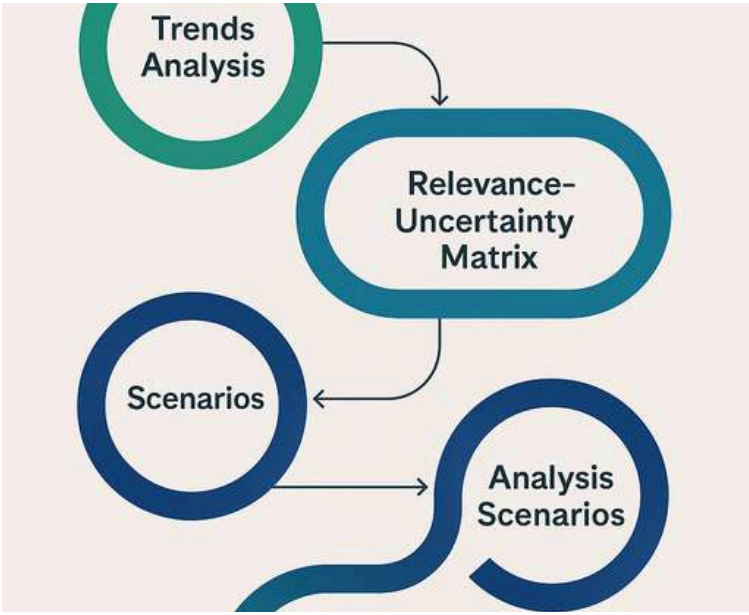
Focus area:

- How does a virtual and hybrid version of such a mass event look like?
- How can it be ensured that whoever person all over the world can take part in the Expo experience and how would such an experience concretely look like?

Guiding Questions

- What is the future of global, decentralized and highly participatory mass events in 2035 and beyond?
- How does a virtual and hybrid World Expo experience look like in 2035 accordingly?

AI-generated image using prompt provided by the authors (via ChatGPT/DALL-E, OpenAI)



Aim of project

- Gather insights into what are pressing questions, challenges and themes looking beyond 2035.
- Create scenarios of a virtual / hybrid mass event such as the Berlin based Expo 2035.
- Develop and visualize the participants’ journeys for the respective Expo concepts.

AI-generated image using prompt provided by the authors (via ChatGPT/DALL-E, OpenAI)

Expected deliverables

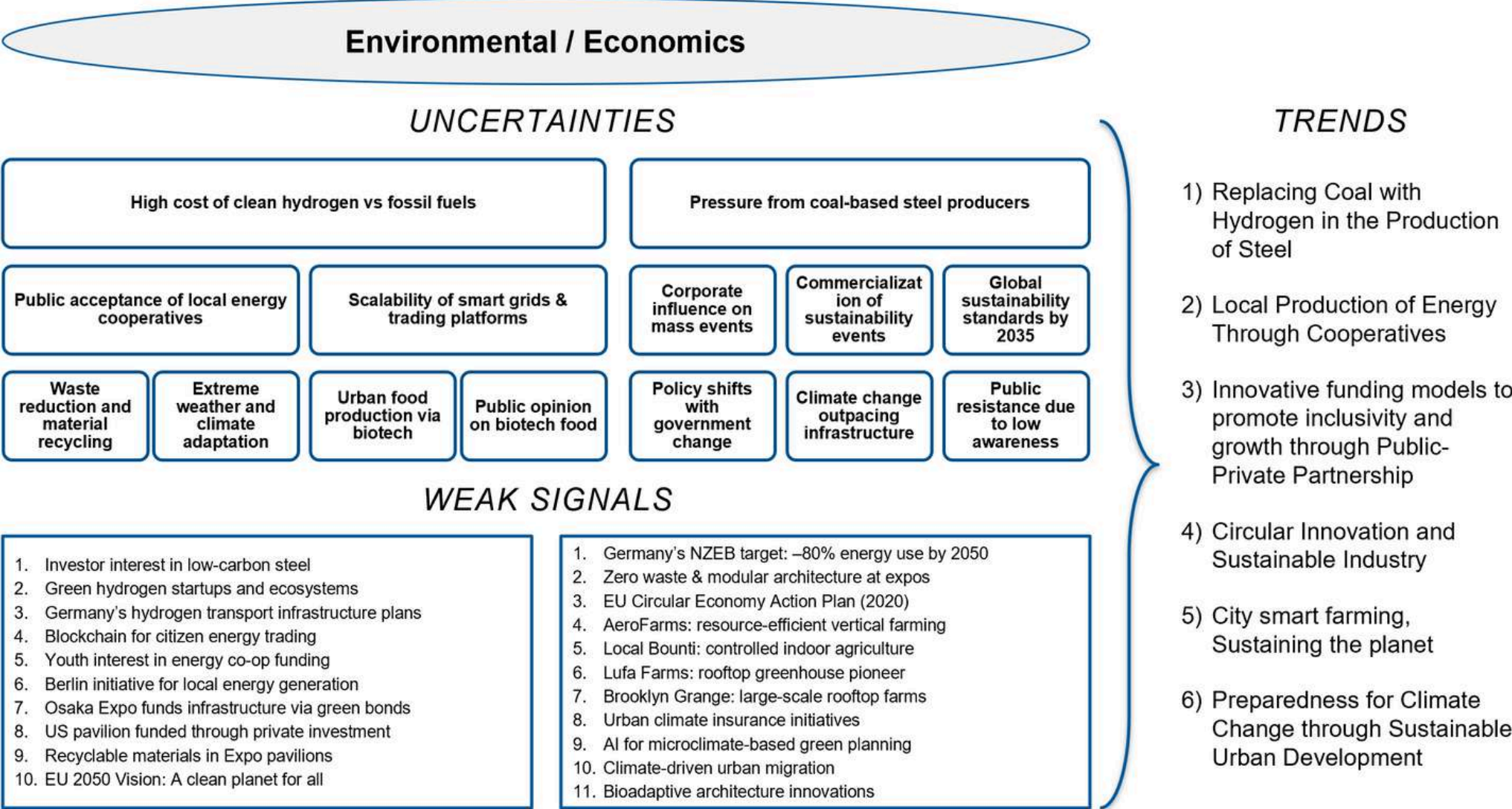
Scenarios of a virtual & hybrid mass events

- What is considered innovative and new in 2035?
- Which developments and questions drive humanity?
- What are critical uncertainties?
- What are the pressing topics, questions and grand challenges crucial to the world until 2045?
- How do (which) technologies influence the world, the people, the cities, living, and concretely a mass event like the World Expo?
- How does technology change the way of showcasing innovations, bringing people together, ensuring inclusiveness and engaging people to participate?

Developing personas showcasing an immersive participants’ journey (2 per group: one robust journey across the scenarios and one specific journey for one chosen scenario):

- What is the actual experience of the virtual & hybrid World Expo? What do (all different kinds of people) think / do / feel?
- How do people interact with either or the virtual and hybrid version of the World Expo? What would the journey of a person participating at the Expo look like, what are touchpoints? How can it be an engaging, participatory and physical boundaries bridging experience?
- What are concrete World Expo experiences of concrete personas all over the world?

Trends of Envirenmental and Economy



Trends of Envirenmental and Economy



Carbon Neutrality by 2045: Replacing Coal with Hydrogen in the Production of Steel

[Trend card](#)



Carbon Neutrality by 2045: Local Production of Energy Through Cooperatives

[Trend card](#)



Transforming the Financing of Mass Events by 2035

[Trend card](#)



Designing Sustainable Exhibitions: A Living Lab for Circular Innovation and Sustainable Industry

[Trend card](#)



Sustainable Bio-Economy: “City smart farming, Sustaining the planet”

[Trend card](#)



Preparedness for Climate Change through Sustainable Urban Development

[Trend card](#)



Polar out-comes

“Influence of Technology on Politics” and
“Preparedness for Climate Change through Urban Development”

Outcome 1 ← **KEY DRIVER** → Outcome 2

Politics of Populism and Hyper-nationalism

Influence of Technology on Politics

Path towards Effective Democracy

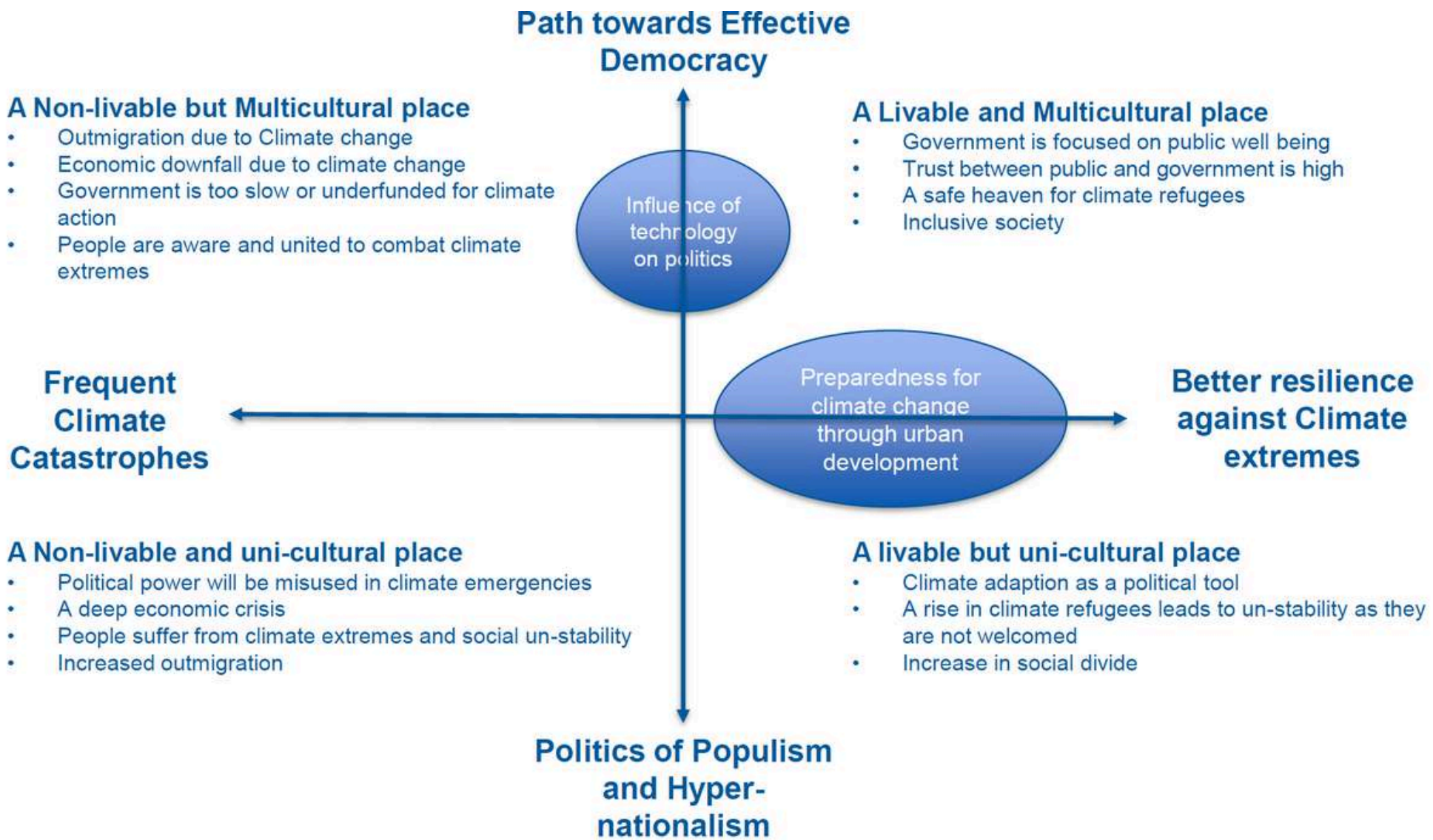
Frequent Climate Catastrophes

Preparedness for Climate Change through Sustainable Urban Development

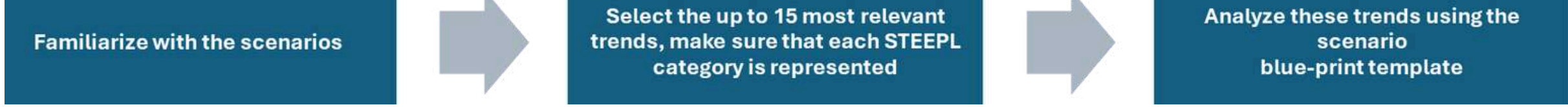
Better resilience against Climate extremes

Scenario Matrix

“Influence of Technology on Politics” and “Preparedness for Climate Change through Urban Development”



The scenario blue-print template



			Scenario 1		Scenario 2		Scenario 3		Scenario 4	
			A Livable and Multicultural place		A livable but uni-cultural place		A Non-livable and uni-cultural place		A Non-livable but Multicultural place	
		Trend	Relevanc e	One sentence...	Relevanc e	One sentence...	Relevanc e	One sentence...	Relevanc e	One sentence...
SOCIO-CULTURAL	1	Youth Culture : The Social Shift in Global Cities	5	Youth culture is becoming a driving force behind mass events, promoting the climate agenda, equality and dialogue between communities, in an atmosphere of trust in government and public.	2	Youth initiatives are allowed, but mass events are formed around a uni-cultural model that emphasizes traditional values, which limits diversity and reinforces the perception of social divide among young people.	2	Amid social crisis, economic difficulties, and growing political control, youth culture is increasingly pushed to the margins and ignored, while mass events serve to reinforce official government ideology rather than represent the voices of the young.	3	In the face of climate change, migration and social un-stability, young people are using mass events as a way to express themselves, strengthen ties between cultures and create new forms of urban identity based on shared challenges.
	2	Identity Expression & Individualism	5	Mass events become open spaces for self-expression, where people from different cultures and backgrounds can freely share their identities.	1	Mass events are organized under government control and support the ideals of national unity, while identity and cultural diversity are move to the background.	1	Mass events become tools of control and propaganda, while rising migration leads to tighter restrictions on cultural expression and public events.	4	Despite limited resources and ongoing economic crises, local initiatives support events that allow residents to express their identities expression and development community networks.
	3	Culture fusion and Hybrid Identities	5	Mass events actively support cultural fusion, where different communities create new hybrid identities through inclusive participation.	2	Mass events promote a uni-cultural image, leaving little space for hybrid identities and intercultural dialogue.	1	Against a background of climate catastrophes, increased outmigration, and growing social instability, mass events no longer reflect cultural diversity; hybrid identities are erased, and more focus is placed on a uni-culture promoted by the government as a way to maintain control.	3	In the context of climate change, outmigration and unfavorable urban environments, mass events become a space for spontaneous interaction between cultures, where new hybrid identities are formed as a way of adaptation and mutual support.

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TECHNO-LOGICAL	1	Smart Wearables as Personal Experience Enhancer	5	These devices could be used for citizen engagement, real-time feedback to public services, and inclusive healthcare access. Multicultural openness encourages adoption of global tech trends.	3	While climate resilience ensures basic infrastructure for wearables, the populist political climate may restrict the kind of experiences wearables offer (e.g., surveillance, ideological filtering).	1	Social unrest, economic collapse, and environmental instability mean there's low availability or affordability for such tech. Wearables might be used by a small elite or for state surveillance, but overall relevance is very low.	2	While democratic openness may encourage innovation and personal freedom, the ongoing climate crises and economic strain reduce focus and resources for wearable tech adoption. Wearables may be used for grassroots organization or health monitoring during crises.
	2	Beyond Biometrics, Toward Conscious Identity: Adaptive Neuro-BioID and the Rise of Digital Entity Authentication in a Post-Human World	5	Conscious ID could enhance access to public services, secure digital voting, and personal data rights. Multicultural inclusion means systems must be fair, inclusive, and non-discriminatory.	4	In a hyper-nationalistic society, the technology may be used to enforce conformity or exclude non-dominant groups. Still relevant, but with possible ethical and civil liberty concerns.	2	While the authoritarian system might desire this tech for mass control and surveillance, the economic and infrastructural collapse limits rollout. Might exist only in elite or state-run institutions with authoritarian goals (e.g., refugee filtering, loyalty scoring).	3	Although the climate crises limit development, democratic values might still push for secure digital identities for climate refugees or aid distribution.
	3	Artificial Intelligence and Robotics	5	AI and robotics are used ethically and inclusively for public good: smart governance, predictive climate management, universal access to services, elder care, and education.	4	AI is used effectively but potentially with ideological bias or surveillance objectives. Robotics aids climate resilience, but technologies may reinforce a mono-cultural narrative (e.g., restricted access, identity profiling).	3	AI may be weaponized or used for authoritarian control and Robotics deployed in limited, militarized or elite sectors. Widespread use unlikely due to economic and infrastructure breakdown.	3	Despite economic and climate hardship, AI may be used in decentralized or community-based systems. Ethical frameworks and civic values promote responsible AI even if tech development is constrained.

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ECONOMIC	1	Local Production of Energy Through Cooperatives	5	Mass events benefit from cleaner, cheaper, and more community-driven energy, enabling sustainable growth and broader regional participation without heavy regulatory pressure from the government.	2	Events remain reliant on traditional power sources, leading to higher costs and missed opportunities for local innovation and resilience, ultimately decelerating progress toward greater sustainability.	1	Energy systems become strained or unreliable due to climate-related disruptions (e.g., heatwaves, storms, blackouts), and without local alternatives, mass events face a higher risk of cancellations, increased operational costs, and/or failures.	5	Mass events become more community driven and resilient, as renewable energy sources such as wind and solar help events remain operational during blackouts caused by severe climate conditions.
	2	Innovative funding models to promote inclusivity and growth through Public-Private Partnership	5	Mass events become more inclusive, accessible, and reflective of diverse communities, with fewer disruptions due to great climate conditions, leading to greater in-person engagement.	4	Mass events are not affected by environmental constraints. However, limited funding from private sectors and reduced innovation are a result of the government's prohibition of public-private partnerships.	3	Along with higher costs and reduced innovation, mass events are more likely to be canceled or moved to a purely online format due to unsafe conditions.	5	Mass events are sustained through adaptive infrastructure and innovation, but the success of these events depend on balancing climate resilience with equal access and inclusivity for all participants.
	3	Circular Economy: A Living Lab for Circular Innovation and Sustainable Industry	5	Mass events become testing platforms for circular innovation solutions, showcasing sustainable practices to the public.	3	Circular innovation practices are used selectively at events to improve image, but true sustainability is limited.	2	Amid economic crises, climate extremes, and social un-stability, circular innovation solutions at events are replaced on quick, unsustainable alternatives, while rising outmigration further loads urban infrastructure.	5	In response to climate change and growing outmigration, cities use local events as platforms for low-waste, circular innovation solutions that strengthen community ties and support inclusive society.

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ENVIRON-MENTAL	1	Replacing Coal with Hydrogen in the Production of Steel	5	Public-private collaboration, skilled multicultural workforce, and trust in governance support large-scale transitions like hydrogen steel. Steel may even become a symbol of green urban growth.	4	The government is climate-resilient and may pursue hydrogen steel for economic and political gain (e.g., energy independence, job creation). However, nationalism may restrict international cooperation or hinder equitable tech access.	1	Economic collapse, political misuse of power, and climate instability make such capital-intensive projects unlikely. The steel sector may deteriorate or fall back on cheaper, dirtier methods.	2	While democratic intent exists, climate catastrophes and limited infrastructure hinder such transitions. The government may want to adopt hydrogen steel, but be too underfunded, slow, or reactive to implement it effectively.
	2	Sustainable Bio-Economy: "City smart farming, Sustaining the planet"	4	In order to address climate adaption, the government promotes for a sustainable bio-economy, but it ignores broad acceptance.	4	In order to address climate adaption, the government promotes for a sustainable bio-economy, but it ignores broad acceptance.	2	Social divisions and financial instability are two factors that contribute to the lack of support for a sustainable bio-economy.	4	To improve resilience in the context of climate uncertainty, the government is implementing sustainable bioeconomy programs.

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POLITICAL / LEGAL	1	Rise of Sustainability-Driven Legislation	5	Mass events evolve into reliable, inclusive, and eco-conscious gatherings, driven by innovation, minimal climate disruptions, and public trust fostered by transparent government sustainability efforts.	5	Despite occurring in climate healthy surroundings, mass events are likely to continue high-impact practices unchecked, leading to greater carbon footprint per event.	5	Mass events face growing disruptions, safety risks, and declining attendance, as government inaction on environmental laws accelerates infrastructure strain and pushes a shift toward digital formats.	5	With sustainability laws in place, mass events in severe climate conditions will adapt through greener practices and climate resilient practices (e.g. flood-proof layouts, renewable energy use), leading to safer, more efficient, and climate-conscious experiences.
	2	The Rise of Exclusion: Nationalism, Xenophobia, and Social Division	1	Social trust and multicultural values counteract xenophobia, while the trend may exist globally, it holds minimal influence within this scenario.	5	Xenophobia fuels instability, especially with incoming climate refugees. The trend is central to the social structure here.	5	Social division, nationalism, and scapegoating likely intensify due to economic and climate crises.	2	While climate disaster destabilizes society, multiculturalism and democracy resist exclusion. Some social tension may arise, but collective unity and awareness mitigate the trend's impact.
	3	Multi-Polarization. Navigating a World Without a Single Power Center	4	A democratic, open society thrives in a cooperative multipolar world, forming diverse global partnerships. Multi-polarization may reinforce inclusivity and decentralized resilience, but also demands skilled diplomacy.	5	Multi-polarization plays directly into populist politics: national pride, selective alliances, and climate cooperation as geopolitical leverage. Countries may resist international pressure on immigration or rights, but align economically on climate tech.	3	In this breakdown scenario, multipolarity may intensify global fragmentation, making coordinated aid and climate response more difficult. The scenario may arise partly due to failed cooperation and competing powers exploiting crises.	4	A decentralized world order may offer lifelines through regional alliances, diaspora networks, and civil coalitions. This society could use multipolarity to access aid, advocate for climate justice, or empower grassroots diplomacy.
	4	Technological Expansion of Government Control	5	Technologies are used transparently, helping to organize mass events with the participation of citizens and respecting for rights, strengthening trust between public and the government.	2	Technology increases control over mass events, allowing for the promotion of a uni-cultural line and the filtering of undesirable forms of expression.	2	In the context of climate catastrophes, mass outmigration and deep economic crisis, mass events are strictly controlled through digital surveillance, turning into controlled rituals that exclude any form of dissent.	3	Technology is used to coordinate and control mass events in the face of increasing climate change and rising outmigrant numbers, but due to a lack of trust in government, it is perceived as a means of repression rather than protection.

Scenario 1

A Livable and Multicultural place

“The City Where the Future Lives”

Newspaper article about EXPO-2035



You don't quite notice the entrance - the flow just carries you in. One step, and you're inside a place where every sound, every movement is part of a larger rhythm. Sidewalks collect energy from your steps. Solar canopies soften the light above. Teenagers nearby debate the next panel on digital rights.

This is more than an EXPO - it's a working model of a city ready for climate challenges. A sustainable, multicultural, and dynamic metropolis where green walkways connect pavilions with homes, drones guide without policing, and screens broadcast debates on AI, migration, and urban ethics.

What struck me most wasn't the technology - it was the atmosphere. Youth weren't just participants - they led. Their projects turned pavilions into dialogue spaces, where listening mattered more than showcasing.

The hybrid cultural projects were especially memorable: Arabic calligraphy layered over Spanish-language poetry, African drumming fused with Nordic electronic beats. It wasn't just integration - it was real cultural fusion, without the need to simplify or smooth out the differences.

The most surprising thing for me was the identification system. It used not only fingerprints or face scans, but also how people act and think. With this system, people could vote, go to the doctor, or share data - all without feeling watched. Here, technology doesn't make people nervous - it makes them feel safe.

AI doesn't govern from above - it supports, walks beside, and adapts to people.

Energy isn't produced somewhere far away - it's generated right in the city: through rooftops, sidewalks, even human movement. Each pavilion runs on energy from local cooperatives, and citizens can trace every kilowatt. Energy here is not a commodity - it's a shared responsibility.

The financial system works the same way. Urban projects are funded through microfinancing, digital grants, and collective investments. Businesses, city authorities, and residents act as partners - not opponents.

In experimental zones, students and engineers test architecture that can be assembled and disassembled like building blocks. Structures are made from recycled materials, food is prepared with zero waste, and the entire system runs on low-emission principles. It's not just a demonstration it's a rehearsal for sustainable city life.

Even heavy industry is evolving. One plant has replaced coal with hydrogen. But the real shift isn't just technical - it's social. The production site has become a place of connection: engineers, migrants, and city workers come together. What they're building isn't just steel - it's a new urban culture.

One greenhouse pavilion, powered by solar and hydrogen, grows food, recycles resources, and runs real tests for the city's bio-economy. It's operational, not experimental.

“We built EXPO as a civic space - where innovation happens through people and shared action”

Everything you once associated with progress isn't behind glass here. No one showcases technology - it's folded into your route, your voice, your breath. In this city, drones don't patrol - they guide. And there are no loudspeakers. Only phrases shared in quiet:

“You feel like you don't need to explain who you are. This place already knows.”

And the tech? Not about spectacle. And to shape the path of urban development – making city life safer and more humane. A man in line for coffee showed me how his smart wearable devices automatically adjust his public transit routes, provide seamless access to digital services, and - most impressively - offer real-time translation when communicating with tourists or new neighbors. In a multicultural society like this, such technologies aren't just trendy - they're a vital bridge between people.

“The technology works. The real challenge is making it feel like everyday life,”

one curator admitted.

Here, laws aren't written behind closed doors - they emerge through civic dialogue. Climate contracts, digital voting, open data - it's governance from the ground up. Technology supports participation, not surveillance. Public trust is built not by control, but by transparency and respect.

In this multicultural city, sustainability is built on respect for diversity. People vote in many languages, and climate is approached through lived experiences - not abstract slogans.

Mass events here aren't just celebrations. They're exercises in resilience: low-emission, zero-waste, and rooted in citizen participation.

And perhaps that's the city's real innovation. Not perfection - but a daily invitation to be part of something shared. A city that doesn't wait for the future. It lives it - with care, with complexity, with everyone.

By our correspondent on site
DER SPIEGEL, May 27, 2035



AI-generated image using prompt provided by the authors (via ChatGPT/DALL-E, OpenAI), video rendering by RunwayML and AI Voice by Canva

Scenario 2

A Livable but Uni-cultural place

“Everything’s Different - But Somehow the Same”

Newspaper article about Film Festival 2035



An honest column by someone still searching for meaning in a perfect city. I went to the Film festival – 2035.

At first, I couldn't figure out what felt wrong.

Everything around me was stunning. The city glowed with precision. Smart stops, AI-curated coffee blends, silent shuttles that arrive the second you finish typing a message.

But after the third film in a row, I realized: I felt nothing. No anger. No inspiration. No spark. Just... quiet.

The film festival? Flawlessly run. Smart wristbands guided you through the schedule. Your seat adjusted based on your biometric data. Even the sound adapted to your emotional profile. No crowds. No confusion. No technical hiccups. This was the future.

“All the films looked different, but they all said the same thing,”

said the guy next to me. And he was right.

Each film tackled “important” themes - sustainable fashion, collective solidarity, digital justice. Every topic was correct. Every production, flawless. But if you closed your eyes and ignored the credits, you couldn't tell one director from another. It was like they all had the same curator. Or editor. Or fear - of stepping outside the frame.

Culture works like GPS now. Straight lines only. No wrong turns.

I remember when culture used to argue. It made mistakes. It shouted.

We're living in a uni-culture. Officially, there's no censorship. Nobody tells you what you can't say. But the system is built in a way that anything different never gets through. Anything that feels off-rhythm, out-of-tone, unapproved — doesn't pass. The algorithm doesn't recommend it. The committee doesn't select it. The platform doesn't see it.

Now it explains. It reassures. And more than anything, it repeats. The curator says what the speaker says. The speaker says what's on the banner. The banner says what the city's official channel already posted that morning.

We call it “resilience.” But it feels like uniformity. Polished harmony, where nothing breaks the frame.

“We’ve gone too far into compatibility,”

a young curator told me.

“It used to be enough to be interesting. Now you have to be aligned.”

And beyond culture, the city wears a mask of progress. Clean. Calm. Controlled. But dig deeper, and contradictions surface.

Mass events boast of clean energy, but still run on old systems. Local energy collectives? Never got scaled.

The private sector? Shut out in favor of total municipal control. No partnerships, no entrepreneurial chaos — just predictable, public prototypes.

Yes, there are circular elements: recycled materials, green slogans, compostable cups.

But much of it serves the image, not the system. As with culture, there's a polished form - and there's what it quietly hides.

Yes, this city works. It's beautiful. Functional. Livable. But it has deleted everything uncertain. Everything messy. Everything truly alive.

And I keep wondering:

And the silence?

It's louder than anything. Migrants, especially those displaced by climate change, are vanishing from view. Their stories aren't told. Their languages aren't heard. Participation is technically open - but practically absent.

We showcase green leadership, international cooperation, climate resilience. But when it comes to migration, dissent, or pluralism - silence.

A curated silence that filters who gets seen, heard, celebrated.

National pride becomes a sorting mechanism: who fits the story, and who quietly disappears from it.

What if ten years from now we wake up and realize - we had everything... except ourselves?



AI-generated image based on a prompt created with ChatGPT, visual rendering by RunwayML



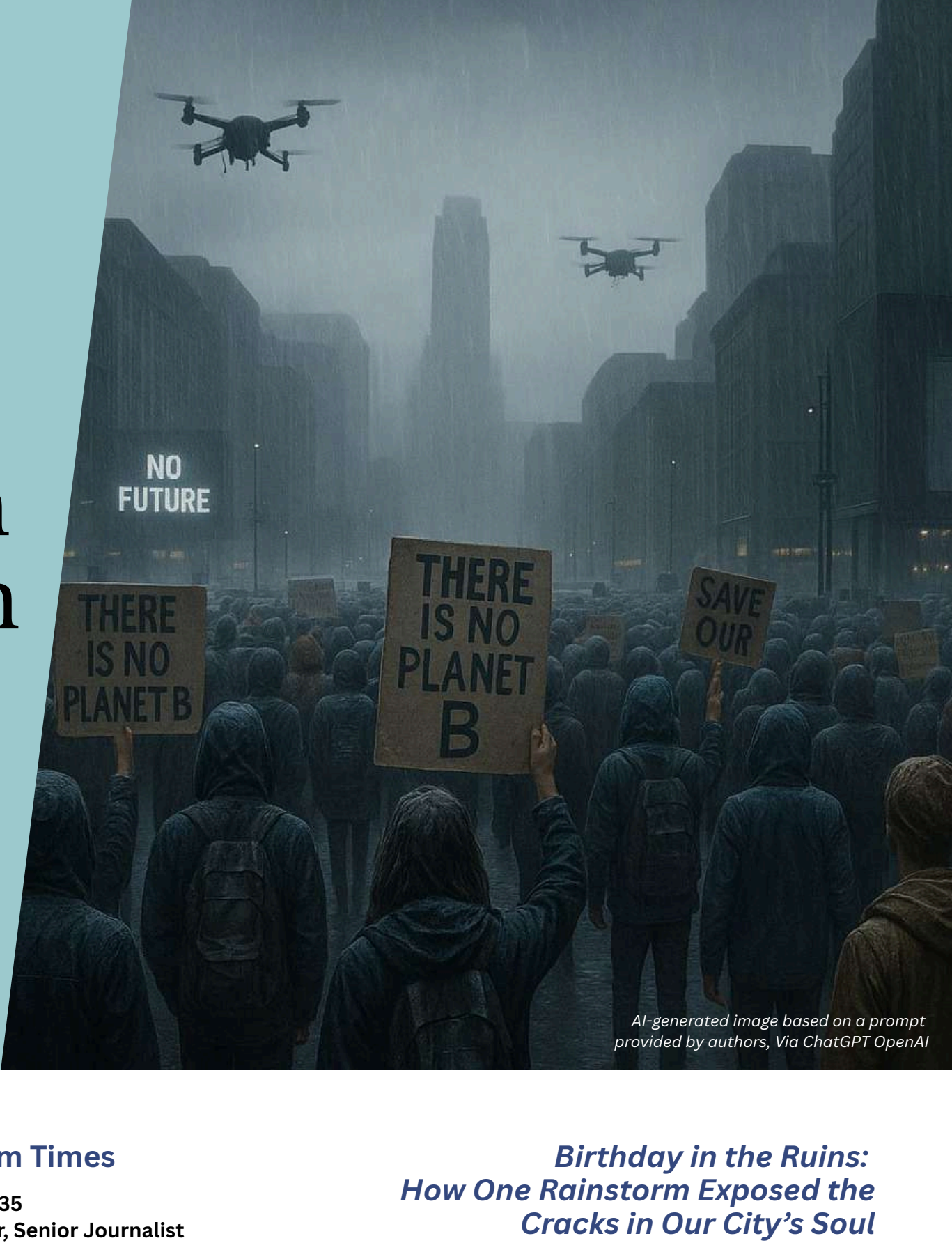
AI-generated image using prompt provided by the authors (via ChatGPT/DALL-E and SORA), OpenAI), video rendering by RunwayML

Scenario 3

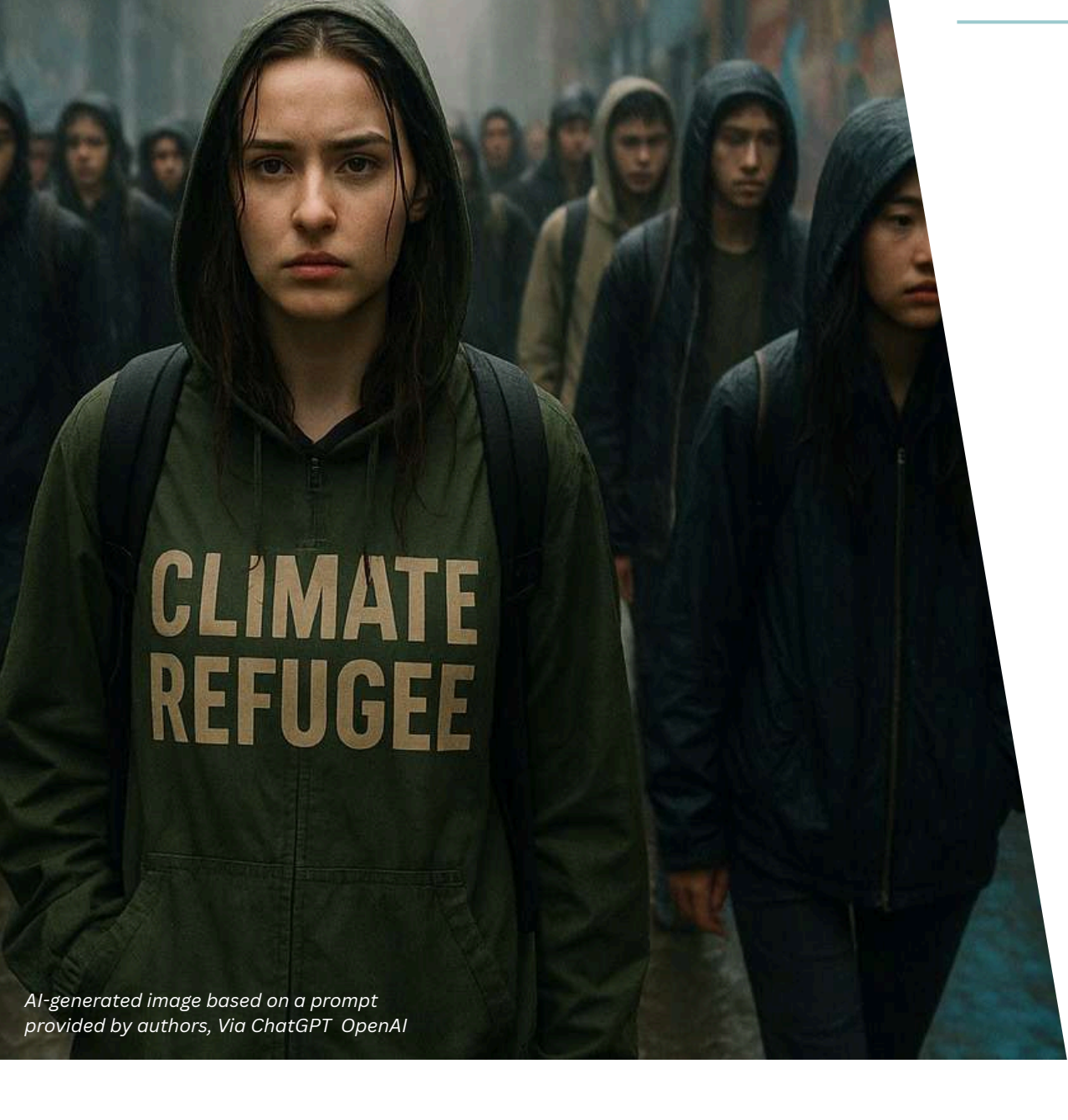
A Non-livable and Uni-cultural place

“How One Rainstorm Exposed the Cracks in Our City’s Soul”

Newspaper article from year 2035



AI-generated image based on a prompt provided by authors, Via ChatGPT OpenAI



AI-generated image based on a prompt provided by authors, Via ChatGPT OpenAI

Tech Dystopia in Disrepair

Some still wear smart patches and neuro-ID bands, but don't let that fool you. These aren't tools of progress—they're badges of privilege and control. The state uses them to track loyalty, filter aid, and scan for dissent. As for AI? Forget any utopian dreams. Most of it's locked in military zones or used for digital policing. The public has neither access nor trust.

Economy of Desperation

Remember when we once dreamed of solar cooperatives and green infrastructure? Today, we depend on outdated grids that fail at the first sign of thunder. Local events are either canceled or moved online—if the networks are even working. Public-private partnerships have collapsed under rising costs and corruption. The circular economy is a concept we discuss in history books now. We rely on disposable fixes, not sustainable solutions.

The Green Mirage

Our leaders talk green, but the reality is coal is back, and dirty industries rule the outskirts. Talk of hydrogen steel is laughable. City farming projects have either failed or turned into elite ventures, inaccessible to the average citizen. The few sustainability-driven laws passed last year have been mostly symbolic, underfunded, or unenforced.

Division is the Only Constant

What hurts the most is the division. Nationalist rhetoric fills our feeds. Climate refugees are blamed for everything—from job scarcity to disease outbreaks. Neighborhoods that once brimmed with cultural exchange now sit in silence, patrolled and monitored.

The Gotham Times
Date: July 3, 2035
By: Peter Parker, Senior Journalist

Today was supposed to be different. It was my birthday. I had planned a small family dinner in Old Centrum—nothing lavish, just a meal under the stars, a moment of peace in this city of sirens. But as we stepped outside, the rain came down like a warning, heavy, unrelenting, and cruel. Within 30 minutes, the streets were flooded. The tram network collapsed. Power outages rolled across the districts. Food delivery drones rerouted and vanished mid-air. Emergency lines were jammed. And once again, the city failed—not just its infrastructure, but its people. And I sat there—wet, tired, angry—not just because my birthday plans were ruined, but because this storm felt like the perfect metaphor for our times.

*Birthday in the Ruins:
How One Rainstorm Exposed the
Cracks in Our City’s Soul*

A City of Ruins Beneath a Facade of Order
This isn't about one rainstorm. It's about a system corroded by denial, held together by propaganda, and ruled by fear. Let's talk plainly.
Youth culture? Silenced.
Once a vibrant force in this city, the youth are now either unemployed or drafted into state programs. Their events—once spaces of creativity and connection—have turned into ideological performances scripted by the state. There's no room for dissent, no celebration of difference.
Identity expression? Criminalized.
In a time when migration is rising due to our worsening climate, our leaders have responded not with empathy, but restrictions. Hybrid identities and multicultural expressions are dismissed as “destabilizing.” Events must now pass through ideological review.

Globally, things are no better. The multipolar world has splintered into factions. Aid is no longer coordinated—it's weaponized. We're caught between indifferent alliances and opportunistic rivals. And at home, the final layer: control through tech. Public events have become stage-managed rituals. Every camera is watching. Every attendee is counted. Spontaneity has been deleted.

No Shelter in the Storm

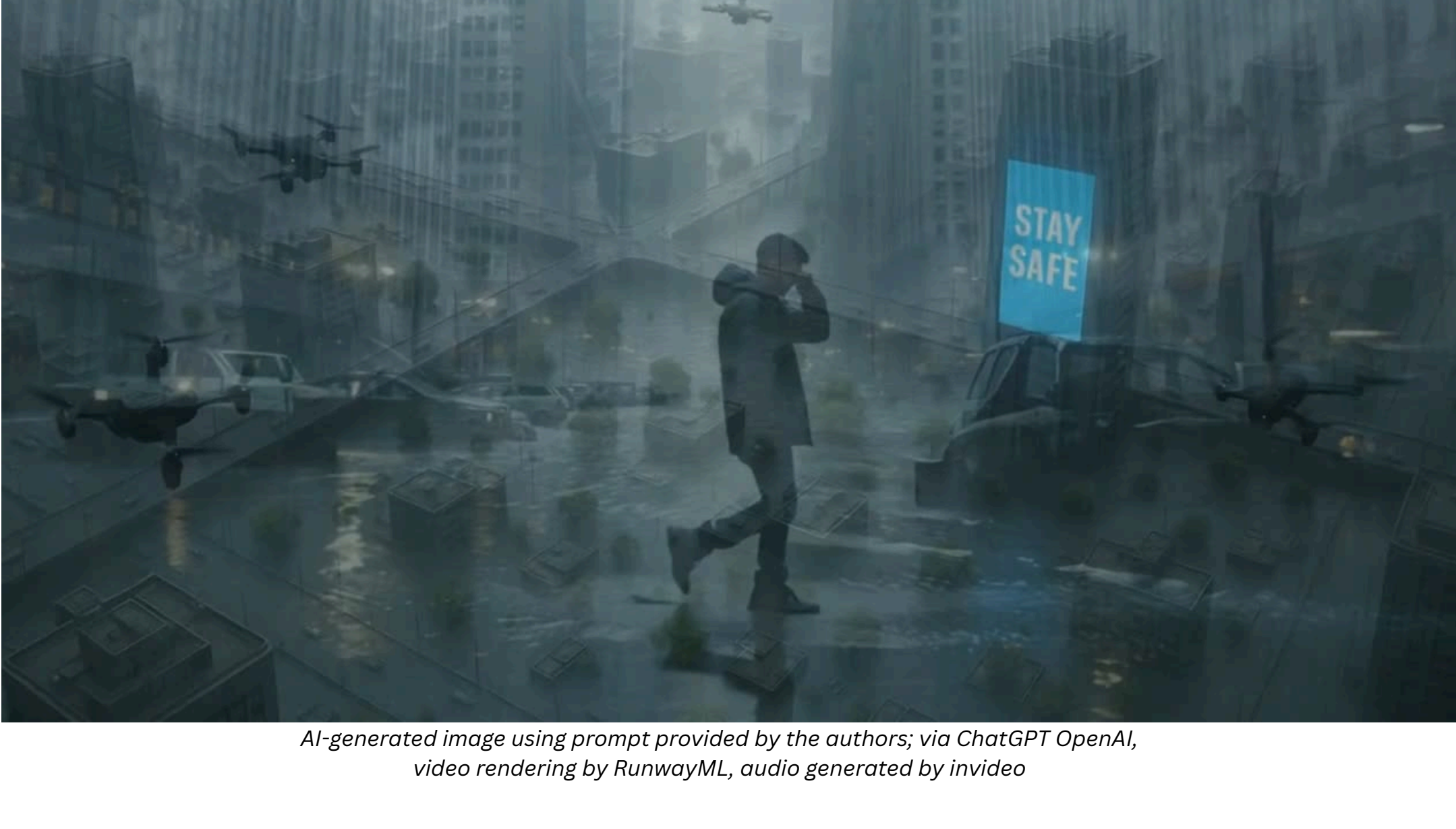
So yes, today's rainstorm was a disaster. But it wasn't just water that poured over this city. It was a flood of truths we've long tried to ignore:

- That we are not resilient.
- That our diversity is being erased.
- That our tech, our laws, our economy—have all been captured by fear.

And I'm tired. Not just of being wet, or missing dinner. But of celebrating another year in a city that punishes those who dream differently.

Final Word

Some will read this and call me bitter. Others might dismiss it as "sentimental journalism." But maybe—just maybe—someone will read this and remember who we were supposed to be. Before the floods. Before the fences. Before the silence.
—Peter



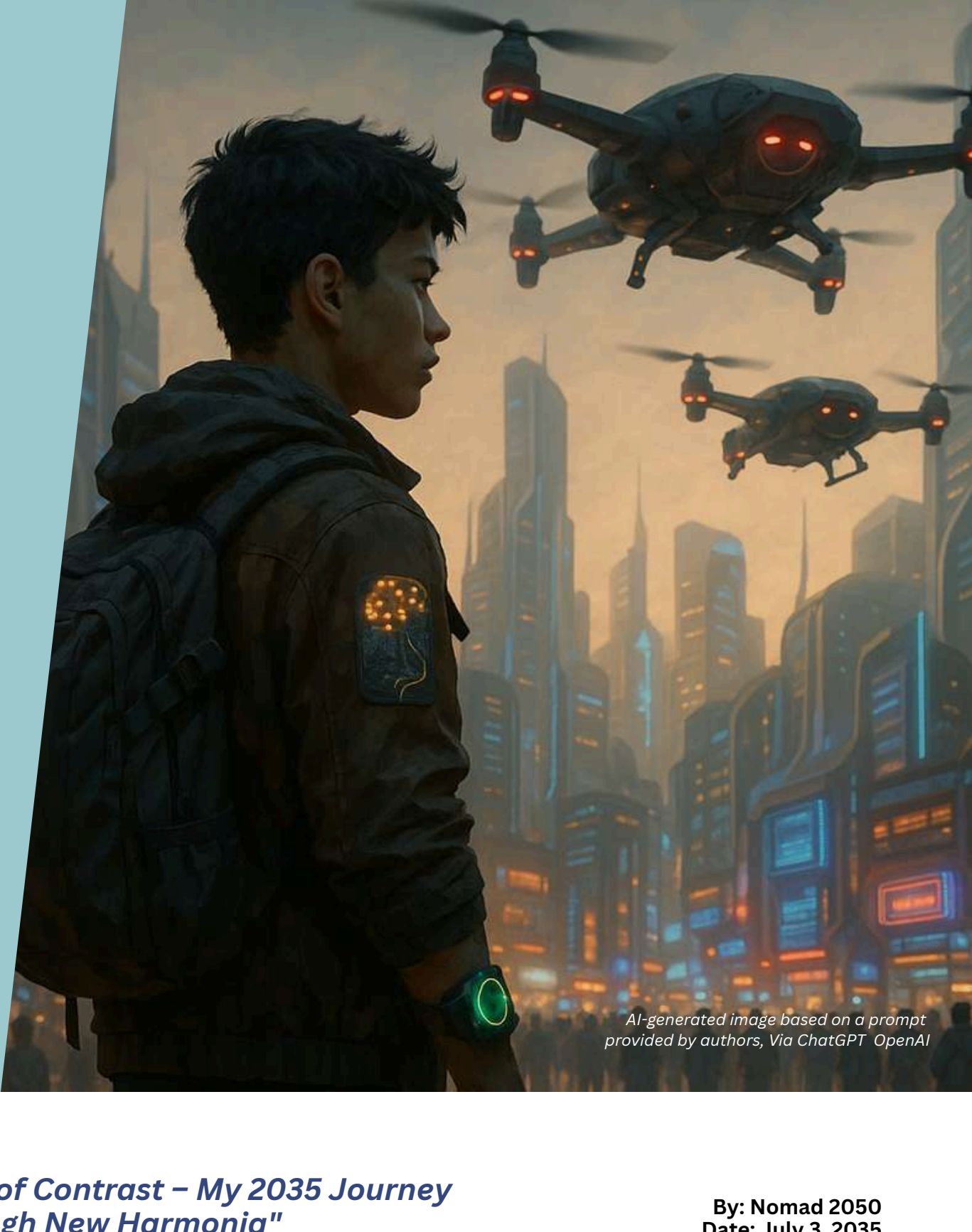
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Scenario 4

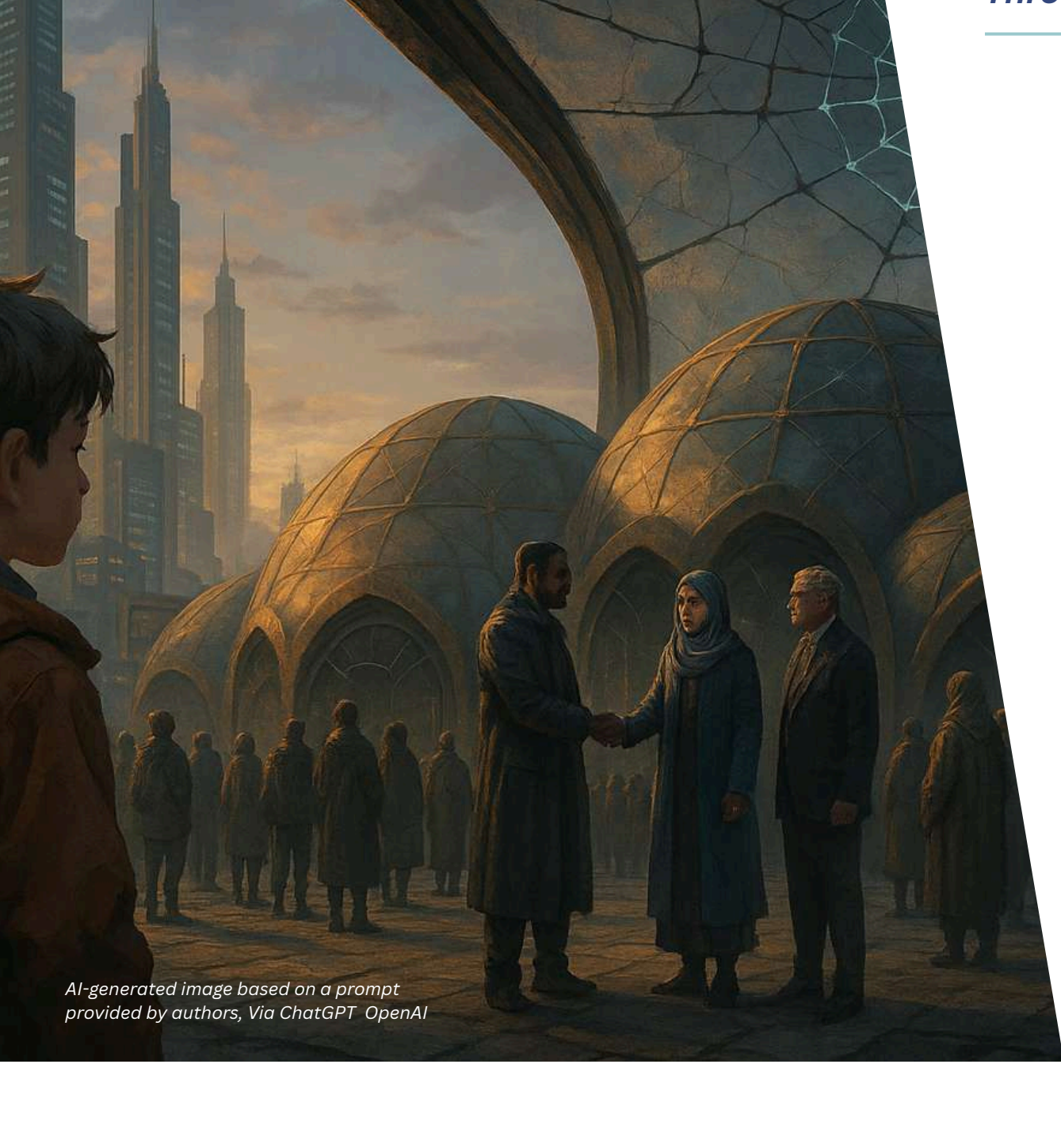
A non-livable but multi-cultural place

“Journey thorough the City of Contrast”

A Travel-blog from year 2035



AI-generated image based on a prompt provided by authors, Via ChatGPT OpenAI



AI-generated image based on a prompt provided by authors, Via ChatGPT OpenAI

The clothes were upcycled, the lights were pedal-powered, and the vibe was pure defiance.

Tech: Power to the People... Mostly

Technology here is a paradox. Smart wearables are everywhere, but not as luxury gadgets. They're DIY-warning health patches, crowd-safety alerts, and even environmental sensors warning of incoming dust storms. Yet, everyone side-eyes the government drones overhead. They fly above every large gathering, claiming to "ensure climate safety." People whisper of biometric scans gone wrong and data sold to external powers. It's a democracy, sure—but trust is thin.

Power from the Crowd, Literally

I visited an abandoned stadium, now reborn as the "Solar Circle", a community-run venue for everything from film nights to disaster shelters. It runs entirely on community-owned wind and solar grids, and uses circular economy practices for waste and energy. During a sudden blackout across the commercial district, the Circle was still glowing, still alive. People gathered like moths to firelight—safe, connected, empowered.

Money and Morality

One part of the city struck me deeply—Green Lot, where mass events only happen through inclusive public-private funding models. The stage was made from reclaimed wood; the lights ran on kinetic floor panels. But the border of the lot told a different story. Those outside the digital ID system—stateless migrants, recent climate escapees—were locked out, sometimes quite literally. A volunteer told me, "We're inclusive... until we're not."

*"City of Contrast – My 2035 Journey
Through New Harmonia"*

By: Nomad 2050
Date: July 3, 2035

I've heard whispers—some call it "The Last Beacon of Urban Multiculturalism", others scoff and say "A Melting Pot on the Edge of Collapse." I couldn't resist. I packed my modular bag, charged my solar drone, and flew into the heart of New Harmonia, a coastal city-state rebuilt by climate survivors, artists, technocrats, and urban refugees. The media couldn't make up its mind about this place. But I've never trusted filtered pixels. I wanted to see it, feel it, live it—the contradictions, the culture, the climate, the chaos.

First Impressions: A City Breathing Through Cracks

The air was hot—scorching and uneven, like the climate couldn't make up its mind either. Flash flood barriers towered at intersections. Solar sails flapped above open markets. And right at the arrival terminal, a group of young artists was organizing what they called a "Resilience Jam"—a mass event blending protest, performance, and poetry, where every voice found rhythm. I asked a young organizer named Leena what the point was. She smiled, "We've lost homes, we've lost hope. But we've found each other."

Identity Everywhere, Yet Nowhere

From food stalls run by Ethiopian-Korean chefs to murals quoting indigenous wisdom in four languages, the fusion of identities was overwhelming, yet organic. You'd think resource scarcity would kill self-expression, but no—local councils actually fund micro-events that celebrate personal stories and cultural heritage. On 9th Avenue, I attended a "Mirror Night"—a block party where people wore clothes representing both their past and future selves.

Concrete Meets Green Dreams

Even amid decay, there are signs of regeneration. Rooftop aquaponics feed dozens of homes. Kids learn soil-less farming in former shopping malls. Despite major policy hurdles and budget shortfalls, the government is trying. Sustainability laws require every new event space to be climate-proof: elevated stages, heat shelters, water catchments. Steel production? Still coal-heavy. Hydrogen dreams exist, but they're dreams. Too expensive. Too delayed.

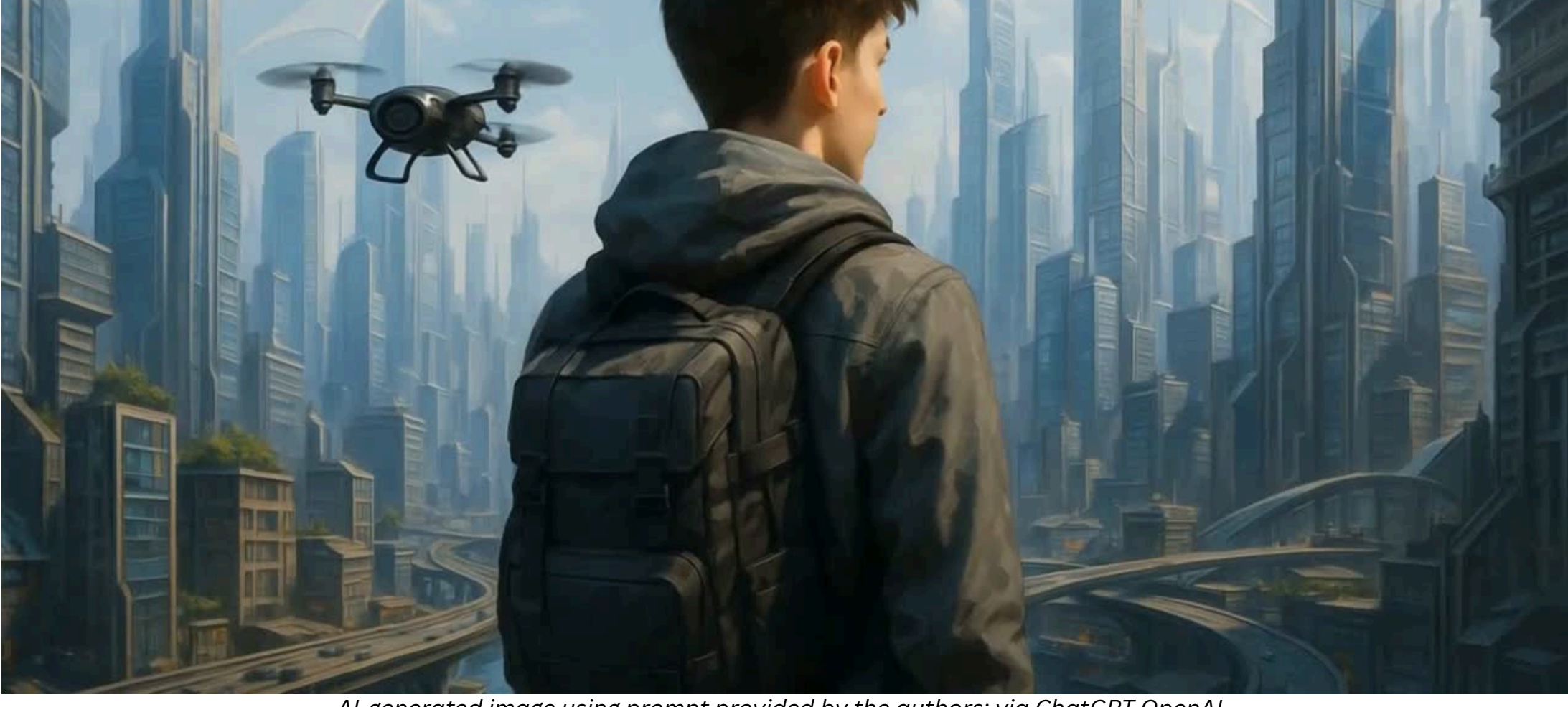
Diplomacy of the Displaced

Strangely enough, New Harmonia survives not because of a single strong leader, but because of coalitions, diasporas, and alliances with other decentralized cities. Aid comes from everywhere and nowhere. Deals are made through encrypted diplomatic circles. This web of interdependence gives it strange resilience. Like a spider on a cracked window—fragile, but persistent.

My Final Note

New Harmonia is not a utopia. It is humid, noisy, underfunded, and in parts unlivable. But it is also multicultural, expressive, and fiercely democratic. Its people are more united than happy, more tired than free, but in them I saw hope as a survival instinct, not a luxury. Media got it wrong. This isn't a city falling apart. It's a city learning to hold itself together.

Next Stop: Cairo Delta Arcology
Let's see how it compares...



AI-generated image using prompt provided by the authors; via ChatGPT OpenAI, video rendering by RunwayML, audio generated by invideo

Implications Matrix

scenarios about the EXPO 2035

	Implications		Scenario 1	Scenario 2	Scenario 3	Scenario 4	Score
			A Livable and Multicultural place	A livable but uni-cultural place	A Non-livable and uni-cultural place	A Non-livable but Multicultural place	
1	The interactive and social function of the exhibition space will play an important role in making visitors more engaged. Description: In the future, exhibition spaces will not only show things — they will become places where people can talk, share, and take part. Visitors will not just watch; they will join the activities and help create the experience.	specific	5	3	0	3	13
2	Digital environments will become proactive, supportive and more intuitive for visitors. Description: Future digital environments and AI systems will not just be navigators, but adaptive assistants that can understand the context, take into account the emotional state, language, cultural background and interests of the visitor. They will not impose, but unobtrusively accompany, offering personalized routes and engaging experiences, making large-scale events more human and accessible to everyone.	robust	5	5	3	3	16
3	The pavilions act as prototypes of sustainable urban infrastructure. Description: These spaces act as functional models of the future city – with renewable energy, circular materials and digital solutions based on citizen participation. They do not simply showcase ideas, but undergo real-life viability tests. After the exhibition, they can be deployed in real cities as practical pieces of future infrastructure, turning EXPO into a tool for long-term urban transformation.	robust	5	5	0	0	10
4	Civic participation will become highly curated through algorithms. Description: Even in digital and open environments, citizen participation will increasingly be filtered by algorithms – through recommendations, moderation, and selection of visible content. This creates the appearance of inclusivity, but can exclude controversial and unconventional voices. The EXPO of the future must seek a balance between manageability and genuine diversity, so that algorithms do not simplify reality, but support the participation of a wide range of groups.	robust	0	5	5	0	10
5	Visible sustainability hides invisible inequalities. Description: Impressive visual sustainability – green technologies, clean spaces, smart solutions – can create a façade of progress that hides social imbalances. When sustainability becomes decoration, the voices of vulnerable and disadvantaged groups can be marginalized. The EXPO of the future must strive not only for external displays of sustainability, but also for deep social inclusion.	specific	1	5	5	1	12
6	Cultural expression may be muted by systemic alignment pressures. Description: In an environment where everything is strictly organized, cultural expression can become monotonous and safe, rather than vibrant and diverse. When only projects that fit the “official tone” receive support and attention, artists and authors begin to repeat themselves and avoid risks. The EXPO of the future must create space for different voices, debate and experimentation, otherwise creativity will become a form of submission.	specific	0	5	5	0	10

Implications Matrix

scenarios about the EXPO 2035

	Implications		Scenario 1	Scenario 2	Scenario 3	Scenario 4	Score
			A Livable and Multicultural place	A livable but uni-cultural place	A Non-livable and uni-cultural place	A Non-livable but Multicultural place	
7	Loss of Global Credibility & Participation: International boycotts or withdrawals may occur due to the host country's authoritarianism, nationalism, and exclusionary policies. Global institutions and multicultural delegations may hesitate to associate with a regime known for human rights suppression and climate negligence.		0	5	5	0	10
8	Security-Driven, Heavily Policed Event: Due to deep social unrest and climate-related instability, the expo would be under intense surveillance, with limited freedom for visitors. Public spaces and pavilions would likely be controlled rituals, promoting state ideology rather than authentic cultural exchange.		0	5	5	3	13
9	Infrastructure Failures and Disruptions: Climate catastrophes—such as flash floods, heatwaves, and power outages—would jeopardize the continuity and safety of the expo. Emergency evacuations, blackouts, or collapsed supply chains could disrupt the visitor experience.		0	0	5	5	10
10	Expo as a Space of Resistance and Solidarity: Despite infrastructure challenges, the expo becomes a platform for inclusion, unity, and resilience. Civil society groups, refugee artists, and multicultural communities could use Expo to voice collective concerns and inspire global solidarity.		5	1	1	5	12
11	Themes of Climate Justice and Adaptation: The core themes of the expo would shift toward climate resilience, disaster adaptation, community innovation, and sustainability. Expect low-budget but high-impact, community-led innovations—like circular economy models, refugee-designed pavilions, and grassroots tech.		5	3	0	2	10
12	Underfunded but Authentically Vibrant: Economic downturn would result in modest installations, but rich cultural diversity and open dialogue would make it a meaningful experience. Hybrid identities and fusion cultures would be celebrated, giving Expo a dynamic and deeply human flavor.		3	0	2	5	10
	Score		29	42	36	27	

Prototype

Persona 1

One robust journey across the scenarios

I. Persona characteristics:

A.Profile card:

Name: Eva Meyer
Age: 34
Nationality: German
Family: Husband (energy engineer), son (7 years old)
Residence: Hamburg, Germany
Education: M.A. in Cultural Studies and Media Communications, Freie Universität Berlin - focus on global and digital cultural change.
Occupation: Cultural researcher at the Hamburg Center for Culture and Digital Society
Languages: German, English



AI-generated image using prompt provided by the authors (via ChatGPT/DALL-E, OpenAI)

- Professional and research Interests:**
- Multiculturalism and cultural transformation
 - Cultural futures in the context of digitalization and climate change
 - The role of AI in reshaping public space and experience
 - Sustainability and cultural heritage
 - Cross-regional collaboration with a focus on Central and Southeast Asia

Information about friends: Eva has friends in both her professional and personal circles. She is currently in close contact with a friend, Amina, from Central Asia, who is researching how the landscape is changing under the influence of climate change.

B.Current Time and Events:

Year: 2035
Event: EXPO, Berlin

- Description event:**
- The EXPO is held in a hybrid format, allowing participation both in person and online
 - This is a technological event that actively uses digital platforms and systems based on artificial intelligence.
 - EXPO shows how life is changing under the influence of climate, technology and the urban environment.
 - Laboratories and pavilions demonstrate models of the future, cultural changes and sustainable solutions.
 - Visitors can not only observe, but also interact with the exhibition, creating personal routes and receiving help from AI assistants.

C. Interests in visiting EXPO:

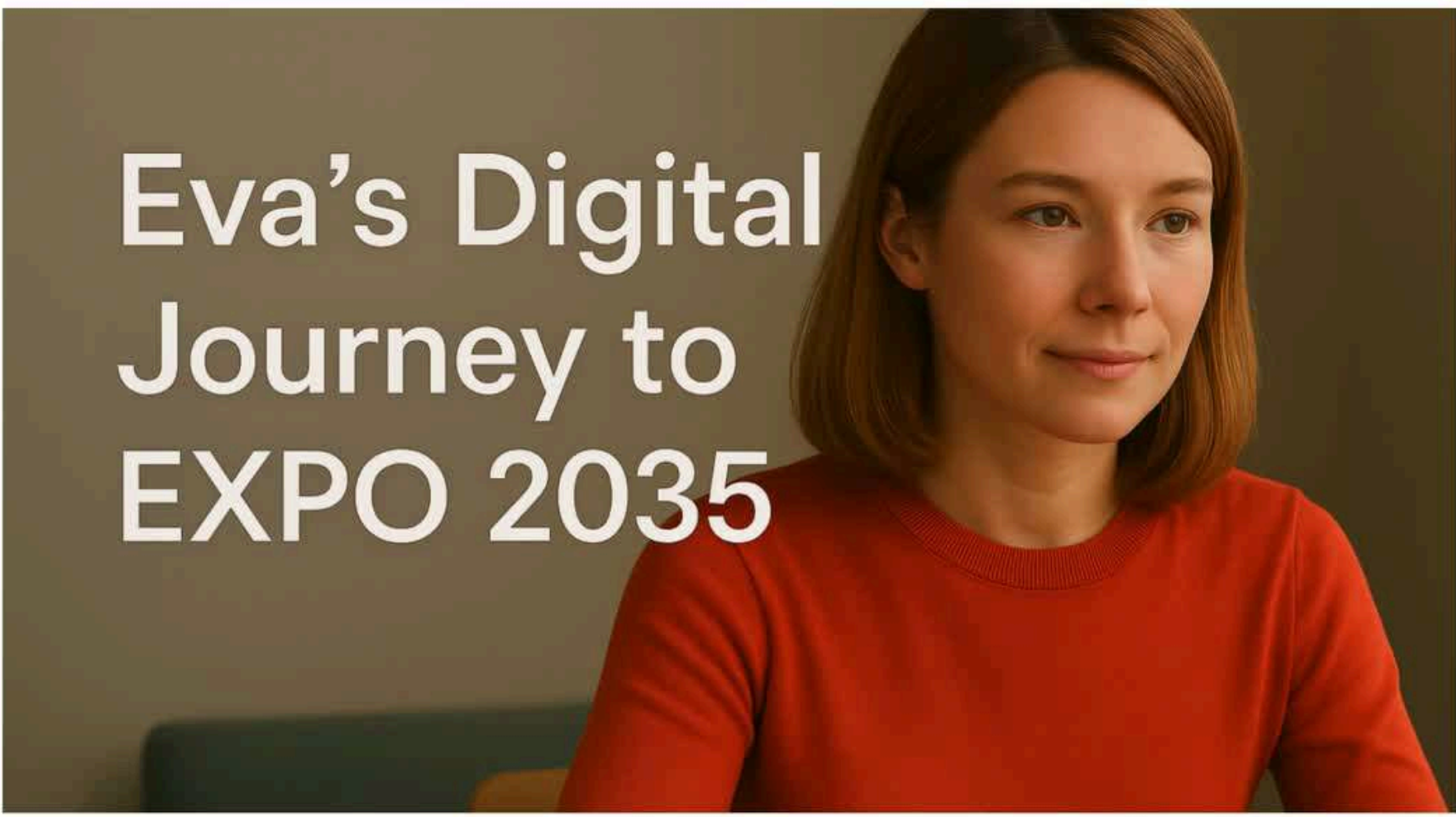
- 1. Professional:** to observe cultural, climatic and technological changes in a live format.
Goal: to get ideas and inspiration for their research.
How: visits digital and physical pavilions, pays attention to labs where climate and cultural models are shown.
- 2. Personal:** to make EXPO a shared family experience.
Goal: to engage husband and child in a conversation about the future.
How: first explores the virtual platform, then plans a family visit to Berlin.
- 3. Social:** to support the participation of a researcher friend from Central Asia.
Goal: to explore the exhibition together through a shared digital journey.
How: they join virtual spaces and attend selected events on climate and changing landscapes, communicating via their avatars in real time.

II. Persona roles

- **Facilitator of the digital journey** - Explores the possibilities of the virtual format of EXPO and creates a route, which she then recommends to a friend for remote participation.
- **Researcher with professional interest** - Observes cultural, climatic and technological changes as part of their research work.
- **Visitor with family** - Organizes a joint visit to EXPO with husband and child, choosing events that are interesting and useful for the whole family.

III. Digital Journey Path

Stage	Touchpoints	Actions	Emotional Response
1. Entry to Platform	AR-lenses, sensor gloves, EXPO Sphere interface	Enters virtual space, sees main menu, selects "Send Invitation"	Curiosity, anticipation
2. Connecting with Amina	Identity confirmation system (voice + gesture + brain signature), avatar sync	Completes authentication, Amina appears, avatars synchronize	Excitement, warmth, connection
3. Exploring EXPO map	Interactive world map, pavilion nodes, voice chat	Navigates with Amina, discusses topics, touches interest points	Engagement, shared discovery, reflective interest
4. World Simulation Pavilion	Four portals with visual immersion	Visits all 4 scenarios, observes differences, shares insights	Cultural excitement, hope, anxiety, critical thinking
5. Conference Participation	Virtual amphitheatre, voice interface, expert speaker, Q&A system	Listens to talk, asks a question, receives follow-up meeting offer	Intellectual stimulation, pride, relevance
6. Warm farewell	Quiet digital dome, virtual river	Chats with Amina, proposes joint project, shares emotional closure	Warmth, appreciation, inspiration
7. Family mode	Family route selector, child-friendly digital environments	Sends link to family, plans shared exploration	Playfulness, joy, care, connection
8. Journey Summary	Personal dashboard with content archive and memory trail	Reviews notes, confirms meeting, sees saved digital path journey with Amina	Satisfaction, reflection, readiness for next steps



AI-generated image using prompt provided by the authors (via ChatGPT/DALL-E, OpenAI), video rendering by RunwayML and AI Voice by Canva

IV.Actual Experience of the Virtual/Hybrid World EXPO 2035

Technological Setup

- Eva enters the EXPO Sphere 2035 platform using AR lenses and haptic VR gloves. She customizes her avatar to reflect her research interests: multiculturalism, digital patterns, and glowing elements.
- The platform supports deep personalization, collaborative access, biometric authentication (voice, gesture, neuro-signature), and an extended dashboard with activity tracking.
- It also includes a holographic map, an AI interface, voice chat, virtual spaces (conference rooms, pavilions, family modules), and 3D platforms for meetings.

Interaction Format

- Eva interacts with the platform using holographic buttons and gestures, voice commands, immersive transitions into pavilions, dialogue with other avatars, and personalized routes.
- She shares routes, creates invitations, participates in virtual conferences, asks questions, engages in dialogue with scientists and friends, and sets up a family experience.
- The AI system helps her with navigation, connects her with other participants, suggests meetings, and supports intelligent dialogue.

Actions

- She enters EXPO Sphere and customizes her avatar.
- She invites Amina to join.
- She synchronizes the route and explores the pavilions.
- She immerses herself in four future scenarios.
- She participates in a conference, asks a question, and books a meeting with a professor.
- She says goodbye to Amina in the digital space.
- She switches to family mode, sharing routes with her husband and son.
- Finally, she reviews the dashboard, including notes, contacts, and materials.

Feelings

Eva goes through a spectrum of emotions:

- Inspiration and anticipation at the beginning.
- Deep engagement and reflection in the pavilions.
- Anxiety and curiosity in scenes of ruined and sterile worlds.
- Pride and confidence after speaking at the conference.
- Warmth and gratitude when talking with Amina.
- Joy and care while creating the family route.
- At the end – a feeling of inspiration, meaning, and belonging to a shared future.

What Eva Thinks, Does and Feels

Thoughts

- Eva reflects on how digital culture and climate change are transforming society and rituals.
- She sees EXPO as a way to understand the future more deeply, connect personal, research, and global aspects, expand her scientific perspective, and strengthen connections with colleagues and family.
- She asks: How can we embed ritual and memory into the algorithms shaping tomorrow's cities?

Prototype

Persona 2

One robust journey across the scenarios

I. Persona characteristics:

Profile card:

- **Name:** Frau Helga Müller
 - **Age:** 78
 - **Language:** German only (Bavarian dialect)
 - **Education:** Basic
 - **Location:** Rural Bavaria
 - **Digital Literacy:** Very low
 - **Personality:** Introverted, private, rooted in tradition
 - **Interests:** Gardening, local radio
- Attitude toward Climate Issues:
Dismissive / apathetic



AI-generated image using prompt provided by the authors (via ChatGPT/DALL·E, OpenAI)

- **Context:** The world in 2035 is under climate emergency; society is heavily regulated by the government. The World Expo (virtual/hybrid) is state endorsed, with the government mandating the participation of every citizen at the EXPO, including the elderly and digitally distant. In addition, the government uses the EXPO as a platform to spread propaganda.

How Helga Interacts with the Expo (Virtual): Shedding Light Upon Her Journey, Touchpoints, and Engagement

Technological Setup:

- Helga receives a state-issued holographic pad/smart wearable preloaded with the Expo platform.
- She is then visited by local government employed staff who sets up the device and guides her with easy-to-use voice-controlled navigation to start up the device.

Interaction Format:

- Fully German, dialect-adapted interface
- AI assistant
- Visual and physical materials—such as postcards featuring Expo artwork, images from her region, and texture-rich items like dried local flowers—are sent to her by post. This is done to bridge the digital-physical gap, making the Expo more accessible and engaging for participants like Helga who have limited digital literacy.

Journey Stages

Stage	Touchpoints	Actions	Emotional Response
Awareness 📧📻	Government-issued letter and radio announcement, linking participation to loyalty and	Hears about obligatory Expo involvement	Hesitant, annoyed
Onboarding 🏠👤	Visit from a government	Holographic pad/wearable is set	Slightly reassured
Engagement 🗣️💬	Interaction Mode	As the device boots on, Helga engages with a holographic	Curious
Exploration 🌍	AI-guided 3D holographic projection	The assistant begins projecting 3D holograms into the air, telling Helga a local story about the	skeptical
Emotional Hook 🎵🌿	Audio-visual and physical memory cues	She opens a government-issued package containing	Nostalgic
Memory Trigger 🗣️📄	Emotional Memory Activation through Sensory-Driven Holography	As the image settles, Helga slowly realizes the gardener is her younger self. The	Reflective
Learning 🌱🍷	Narrative Hologram of Climate-Resilient Innovation	The AI assistant now depicts Helga in her present state, discovering and	Enlightened



AI-generated image using prompt provided by the authors (via ChatGPT/DALL·E, OpenAI), video rendering by FLIKI

Actual Experience of the Virtual/Hybrid World EXPO 2035: What Helga Thinks, does and feels

1. THINKS:

- "Warum muss ich mich damit beschäftigen? Ich verstehe das alles nicht."
("Why do I have to bother with this? I don't understand any of it.")
- Unsure why this Expo matters to her life.
- Overwhelmed by futuristic tech.

2.DOES

- As the holo-pad/wearable Includes voice control, Frau Helga does not need to navigate complex menus — the device boots up and a virtual AI assistant talks to her in her dialect, providing her with touchless navigation, and accessibility features which she requires due to her low-tech. literacy. She uses voice commands, resulting in the virtual AI assistant guiding her through the exhibition and telling her a story by projecting 3D holograms into the air, displaying local climate impacts on her own village's plants which are dying due to intense heat.
- She begins to hear the melody of a familiar folk tune as the AI assistant guides her into a virtual rural landscape - first showing a young Helga surrounded by flourishing herbs, then transitioning to imagery of her present self, now experimenting with innovative ways to grow plants in climate-resilient soil.

3. FEELS

- Initially: Confused and withdrawn.
- Then: Mild curiosity, comforted by familiar voices and imagery.
- Finally: A surprising emotional shift — she recalls a time past where the wildflowers and herbs she once grew in her garden no longer bloom as they used to. That quiet disappearance now feels deeply personal.

ABOUT TASK

The project “**The Future of EXPO**” was developed as part of the course “**Project Future Life Worlds**”, under the supervision of **Prof. Dr. Jan Oliver Schwarz** and **Prof. Dr. Laura Bechthold**.

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visual rendering by RunwayML*

